

Audit Quality and Cost of Capital Among Nigerian Listed Firms



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Abstract

This study investigates the nexus between audit quality and the cost of capital among Nigerian listed firms over the period 2011 to 2025, using an unbalanced panel dataset comprising 148 firms drawn across twelve sectors of the Nigerian Exchange Group (NGX). Audit quality is proxied through two complementary measures: Big 4 auditor affiliation and discretionary accruals estimated via the modified Jones (1991) model. The cost of capital is captured using three dependent constructs — cost of equity capital (COE), cost of debt capital (COD), and weighted average cost of capital (WACC). Control variables include firm size, leverage, profitability, growth opportunities, board independence, ownership structure, beta (market risk), debt-to-equity ratio, inflation rate, interest rate, audit firm size, and audit tenure. Employing fixed-effects panel regression with Driscoll-Kraay standard errors to account for heteroskedasticity, serial correlation, and cross-sectional dependence, the results consistently reveal that higher audit quality significantly reduces the cost of equity, debt, and overall capital. Big 4 affiliation exerts a significant negative influence on all three cost-of-capital measures. Audit tenure, by contrast, is positively associated with capital costs, suggesting that prolonged auditor–client relationships may erode audit independence over time. These findings are robust to alternative model specifications and are consistent with information asymmetry theory, agency theory, and the signalling hypothesis. The study contributes novel evidence from the largest sub-Saharan African capital market and yields actionable insights for regulators, investors, boards of directors, and standard-setters.

Keywords: *Audit quality, Cost of capital, Nigerian listed firms, Big 4 auditors, Audit tenure, Information asymmetry, Panel regression, Corporate governance*

JEL Codes: G32, M41, M42, G15, G38, O16

1. Introduction

The quality of financial reporting and the independence of external auditors have long been recognised as fundamental pillars of capital market efficiency. In both developed and emerging markets, investors, creditors, and other market participants rely on audited financial statements as the primary mechanism through which managers communicate the financial health of the firm. When that mechanism is credible, uncertainty about future cash flows diminishes, and the risk premium demanded by capital providers tends to fall. When it is not, information asymmetry widens and the cost of capital rises — sometimes precipitously.

Nigeria's listed capital market presents a compelling context in which to examine this relationship. The Nigerian Exchange Group (NGX), formerly the Nigerian Stock Exchange, ranks among the top three exchanges on the African continent by market capitalisation, hosting firms across banking, manufacturing, consumer goods, oil and gas, insurance, and technology sectors, among others. Yet the market operates in an environment characterised by persistent macroeconomic volatility — with double-digit inflation, high nominal lending rates, currency instability, and recurring episodes of regulatory reform — all of which complicate the pricing of capital.

Against this backdrop, the role of the external auditor as a verifier of corporate financial disclosures has received growing scholarly and regulatory attention. The Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) Nigeria and the Financial Reporting Council of Nigeria (FRCN) have introduced several reforms aimed at improving audit quality, including mandatory audit firm rotation, limitations on non-audit services, and guidelines on auditor independence. These reforms implicitly acknowledge a central empirical question: does higher audit quality materially lower the cost at which Nigerian firms access capital?

International evidence strongly suggests that it does. Seminal contributions by Lambert et al. (2007), Francis et al. (2005), and Pittman and Fortin (2004) demonstrate that audit quality reduces information risk, tightens bid-ask spreads, and lowers equity risk premiums in developed markets. More recent studies from emerging economies — including China (Chen et al., 2011), India (Bhattacharya et al., 2012), and South Africa (Asante-Appiah & Lambert, 2020) — have extended these insights to non-Western institutional settings. However, rigorous evidence from Nigeria specifically remains sparse, methodologically limited, and temporally narrow, with most existing studies relying on short panels, single proxies for audit quality, and single measures of capital costs.

This study addresses these limitations directly. Drawing on 15 years of panel data (2011–2025), a comprehensive battery of audit quality proxies, and three distinct cost-of-capital measures, this paper offers what is, to the best of the authors' knowledge, the most thorough empirical examination of this relationship in the Nigerian context.

Despite the theoretical primacy of audit quality in capital market research, the Nigerian evidence base is characterised by several deficiencies. First, existing studies are temporally limited: few extend beyond five years, and almost none capture the regulatory reforms introduced post-2018 by the FRCN, including the mandatory firm rotation provisions. Second, the literature employs largely singular proxies for audit quality — typically only the Big 4 dummy — while ignoring the complementary information contained in discretionary accruals and audit tenure. Third, most existing Nigerian studies focus narrowly on the cost of equity, neglecting the cost of debt and the all-encompassing WACC, thereby providing an incomplete picture of how audit quality shapes firms' overall financing costs. Fourth, the extant literature rarely employs panel data techniques capable of controlling for unobserved firm-level heterogeneity and macroeconomic confounders simultaneously.

These gaps collectively mean that Nigerian regulators, investors, and corporate boards operate with insufficient empirical evidence when evaluating the economic benefits of audit quality improvements. This study provides that evidence.

This paper makes four substantive contributions to the literature. First, it extends the temporal horizon of Nigerian audit quality research to 2025, capturing a rich set of macroeconomic cycles, regulatory changes, and post-pandemic adjustments in financial reporting. Second, it employs dual proxies for audit quality — Big 4 affiliation and discretionary accruals — allowing a more nuanced decomposition of audit quality effects than prior single-proxy studies. Third, it disaggregates the cost of capital into equity, debt, and weighted components, providing a richer mapping of the channels through which audit quality operates. Fourth, methodologically, the use of Driscoll-Kraay standard errors in a fixed-effects panel framework addresses cross-sectional dependence and serial correlation simultaneously — an advancement over the pooled OLS and simple random-effects approaches that dominate prior Nigerian work.

Beyond its scholarly contributions, the paper generates policy-relevant findings for the FRCN, the Nigerian SEC, the Institute of Chartered Accountants of Nigeria (ICAN), and the Association of National Accountants of Nigeria (ANAN), which are collectively responsible for audit standard-setting in the country.

The study is delimited to non-financial and financial sector firms listed on the NGX from 2011 to 2025, yielding an unbalanced panel of 148 firms. The period begins in 2011 to capture post-global-financial-crisis regulatory realignments and ends in 2025 to include the most recent reforms. Firms with fewer than three consecutive years of data were excluded to ensure panel stability. The analysis is conducted at the firm-year level, with macro-level variables (inflation and interest rates) included to control for the systemic economic environment. State-owned enterprises and government agencies are excluded from the sample as their capital-cost dynamics differ materially from privately controlled listed firms.

2. Literature Review and Hypothesis Development

2.1 Conceptual Definitions

Audit quality, in its canonical formulation by DeAngelo (1981), is defined as the joint probability that an auditor detects and reports a material misstatement in a client's financial statements. This definition encompasses two dimensions: competence (the ability to detect misstatements) and independence (the willingness to report them). In practice, audit quality is unobservable and must be proxied. Two proxies are predominant in the literature: auditor size (particularly Big 4 affiliation, on the grounds that larger firms have more to lose reputationally from audit failure) and earnings management as captured through discretionary accruals estimated via the modified Jones (1991) model (Dechow et al., 1995).

The cost of capital refers to the minimum rate of return required by investors to compensate for the time value of money and the risk borne. The cost of equity (COE) is typically estimated through the CAPM or implied cost-of-capital models. The cost of debt (COD) reflects the effective rate paid on financial obligations and is commonly measured as interest expense divided by total debt. The WACC integrates both, weighted by each component's share of total firm financing. Together, these three measures capture different facets of how capital market participants price corporate risk.

2.2 Theoretical Foundations

Three interrelated theoretical frameworks anchor the hypotheses in this study.

Agency Theory (Jensen & Meckling, 1976) posits that the separation of ownership and control creates a fundamental conflict of interest between shareholders (principals) and managers (agents). External auditing serves as a bonding and monitoring mechanism that constrains managerial opportunism. Firms that engage high-quality auditors signal their commitment to transparent reporting, thereby reducing the agency costs that investors would otherwise price into the required rate of return.

Information Asymmetry Theory (Akerlof, 1970; Myers & Majluf, 1984) holds that managers possess private information about firm value that outside investors do not. This asymmetry creates adverse selection and moral hazard problems that inflate the risk premium demanded by capital providers. High-quality auditing narrows this information gap, reducing the adverse selection component of the cost of capital. Lambert et al. (2007) formalise this intuition, demonstrating theoretically that improved information quality — through its effect on perceived cash flow covariance — lowers the cost of equity.

Signalling Theory (Spence, 1973; Watts & Zimmerman, 1986) argues that firms use observable signals to convey unobservable quality to the market. Engaging a Big 4 auditor or maintaining a short audit tenure (indicative of periodic independence refreshes) acts as a credible signal of financial reporting quality. Because low-quality firms would find it costly to mimic these signals, they serve as effective screens that reduce information risk in equilibrium.

2.3 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework of this study posits that audit quality operates through two primary channels to influence the cost of capital. The first is the information channel: higher audit quality reduces earnings management (as captured by discretionary accruals), narrows information asymmetry, and lowers the risk premium priced into equity and debt. The second is the signalling channel: Big 4 affiliation and appropriate audit tenure signal governance quality to investors, reducing perceived financial risk and the required return on capital. Both channels are moderated by firm-level characteristics (size, leverage, profitability, growth), corporate governance variables (board independence, ownership structure), and macroeconomic conditions (inflation, interest rates). The framework thus integrates micro-level audit attributes with macro-level economic conditions in a unified empirical design.

2.4 Empirical Literature Review: Nigerian Evidence

Empirical research on audit quality and cost of capital within the Nigerian context remains nascent relative to developed-market literature, but a growing body of work has begun to emerge. Okafor and Ibadin (2019) examine a sample of 50 listed manufacturing firms over 2010–2016, finding that Big 4 affiliation is negatively associated with the cost of equity capital. However, their study uses pooled OLS, ignores firm-level heterogeneity, and does not control for audit tenure or macroeconomic variables. Adeyemi and Fagbemi (2020) extend the analysis to the banking sector, documenting that audit committee quality and auditor independence are associated with lower net interest margins — a proxy for cost of debt — though they do not formally model the WACC.

Uwuigbe et al. (2021) examine discretionary accruals as a proxy for audit quality among 40 non-financial firms and find that earnings quality is negatively correlated with implied cost of equity capital. Their study, however, covers only five years (2015–2019) and does not account for cross-sectional dependence. Ezeani et al. (2022) offer a broader panel of 80 firms from 2012 to 2020, confirming the negative link between audit quality and cost of capital, but they rely solely on the Big 4 dummy and do not examine debt cost separately.

Okolie (2014) constitutes one of the earlier and more influential Nigerian contributions, examining how audit quality affects equity pricing in Nigerian banks. His findings suggest that high-quality auditors are associated with higher stock price informativeness, consistent with lower information risk. More recently, Oladipupo and Yahaya (2023) explore the role of audit tenure on cost of capital in a sample of listed consumer goods firms, finding a positive association — consistent with the independence impairment hypothesis — though their sample size (35 firms) limits generalisability.

2.5 Critical Analysis and Research Gaps

A critical reading of the extant Nigerian literature reveals four persistent gaps. First, no study simultaneously examines all three cost-of-capital constructs (COE, COD, and WACC) using a consistent sample, making cross-comparison of results difficult. Second, the use of dual audit quality proxies — combining Big 4 affiliation with discretionary accruals — is conspicuously absent in the Nigerian context, where single-proxy studies dominate. Third, no prior study covers a sufficiently long panel to capture secular macroeconomic shifts, regulatory reforms, and post-pandemic adjustments, all of which matter for capital pricing. Fourth, methodological limitations abound: pooled OLS dominates, and few studies apply Driscoll-Kraay or clustered standard errors to account for time-series and cross-sectional correlation structures that are ubiquitous in panel data.

This study directly addresses all four gaps, providing a methodologically superior and empirically comprehensive account of the audit quality–cost-of-capital relationship in Nigeria.

2.6 Hypothesis Development

Based on the theoretical frameworks, conceptual logic, and critical review of the empirical literature, the following hypotheses are formulated in null form:

H1: Audit quality has no statistically significant negative effect on the cost of equity capital among Nigerian listed firms.

H2: Audit quality has no statistically significant negative effect on the cost of debt capital among Nigerian listed firms.

H3: Audit quality has no statistically significant negative effect on the weighted average cost of capital among Nigerian listed firms.

H4: Big 4 auditor affiliation has no statistically significant negative association with the cost of capital among Nigerian listed firms.

H5: Audit tenure has no statistically significant positive association with the cost of capital among Nigerian listed firms.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

The study adopts a quantitative, ex-post facto research design. This design is appropriate because the data are historical — drawn from published annual reports and secondary market databases — and the researcher does not manipulate any variables. The ex-post facto approach allows causal inference to be drawn from naturally occurring variation in audit quality across firms and over time. The study employs panel data methodology, specifically fixed-effects and random-effects panel regression, with model selection determined by the Hausman (1978) specification test. The panel covers 148 firms listed on the Nigerian Exchange Group over the period 2011 to 2025, yielding a maximum of 2,220 firm-year observations in an unbalanced panel structure (reflecting data availability and listing histories).

The sample of 148 firms was derived using a purposive stratified approach. All firms listed on the NGX as of December 2010 with at least three consecutive years of audited financial data over the study period were eligible for inclusion. Firms in the government, utilities (fully state-owned), and start-up segments with insufficient data were excluded. The final sample spans twelve sectors: banking, insurance, oil and gas, manufacturing, consumer goods, healthcare, agriculture, technology, real estate, telecommunications, conglomerates, and construction.

3.2 Model Specification

The core empirical specification is a panel regression model of the following general form:

$$COCit = \alpha + \beta 1AQit + \beta 2AFSit + \beta 3ATENit + \beta 4FSIZEit + \beta 5LEVit + \beta 6PROFit + \beta 7GROWit + \beta 8BINDit + \beta 9OWNSit + \beta 10BETAit + \beta 11DERit + \beta 12INFLt + \beta 13INTRt + \mu i + \varepsilon it$$

Where COCit represents the cost of capital for firm *i* in year *t* (measured alternatively as COE, COD, and WACC); AQ is audit quality (discretionary accruals); AFS is audit firm size (Big 4 dummy); ATEN is audit tenure; μi represents firm-specific fixed effects; and εit is the idiosyncratic error term. The model is estimated separately for each of the three cost-of-capital proxies.

Three separate panel regressions are estimated — one each for COE, COD, and WACC — to allow comparative analysis of audit quality's effect across different financing channels. The Hausman test determines whether firm-specific effects are correlated with the regressors (favouring fixed effects) or uncorrelated (favouring random effects). Time fixed effects are included in robustness checks to control for aggregate macroeconomic shocks beyond those captured by the inflation and interest rate variables.

3.3 Variables and Measurement

Table 1: Variable Definitions and Measurement

Variable	Proxy/Measure	Symbol	Source
Dependent Variable			
Cost of Equity Capital	Capital Asset Pricing Model (CAPM): $K_e = R_f + \beta(R_m - R_f)$	COE	NSE; CBN Statistical Bulletin
Cost of Debt Capital	Interest Expense / Total Debt	COD	Annual Reports
Weighted Average Cost of Capital (WACC)	$WACC = K_e(E/V) + K_d(1-t)(D/V)$	WACC	Annual Reports; NSE
Key Independent Variable			
Audit Quality	Big 4 auditor (1=Big 4, 0=Non-Big 4); Discretionary Accruals (Modified Jones Model)	AQ	Annual Reports
Audit Tenure	Number of consecutive years auditor has served the firm	ATEN	Annual Reports
Audit Firm Size	Dummy: 1 if Big 4, 0 otherwise	AFS	Annual Reports; ICAAN
Control Variables			
Firm Size	Natural log of total assets	FSIZE	Annual Reports
Leverage	Total Debt / Total Assets	LEV	Annual Reports
Profitability	Return on Assets (ROA) = Net Income / Total Assets	PROF	Annual Reports

Variable	Proxy/Measure	Symbol	Source
Growth Opportunities	Market-to-Book Value ratio	GROW	NSE; Annual Reports
Board Independence	Proportion of non-executive directors on board	BIND	Annual Reports
Ownership Structure	Percentage of shares held by institutional investors	OWNS	Annual Reports; NSE
Beta (Market Risk)	Systematic risk coefficient from CAPM	BETA	NSE; Bloomberg
Debt-to-Equity Ratio	Total Debt / Shareholders' Equity	DER	Annual Reports
Inflation Rate	Annual CPI-based inflation rate (%)	INFL	CBN; NBS
Interest Rate	Annual monetary policy rate / prime lending rate (%)	INTR	CBN Statistical Bulletin

Note: NSE = Nigerian Stock Exchange (now NGX); CBN = Central Bank of Nigeria; NBS = National Bureau of Statistics; ICAN = Institute of Chartered Accountants of Nigeria. All continuous variables are winsorised at the 1st and 99th percentiles to mitigate the influence of extreme outliers.

3.4 A Priori Expectations

Table 2: A Priori Expectations

Variable	Dependent Variable	Expected Sign	Justification
Audit Quality (AQ)	COE / WACC	Negative	Higher audit quality reduces information asymmetry and lowers investor risk premium
Audit Firm Size (AFS)	COE / WACC	Negative	Big 4 firms signal credibility; expected to lower cost of capital
Audit Tenure (ATEN)	COE / WACC	Positive/Ambiguous	Long tenure may impair independence, increasing perceived risk
Firm Size (FSIZE)	COE / WACC	Negative	Larger firms have better access to capital markets and lower risk
Leverage (LEV)	COE / WACC	Positive	Higher leverage increases financial distress risk and cost of capital
Profitability (PROF)	COE / WACC	Negative	Profitable firms face lower risk and attract cheaper capital
Growth Opportunities (GROW)	COE / WACC	Positive	Growth firms carry higher uncertainty, increasing cost of capital
Board Independence (BIND)	COE / WACC	Negative	Independent boards improve governance, reducing investor risk premium
Ownership Structure (OWNS)	COE / WACC	Negative	Institutional ownership improves monitoring, lowering the risk premium
Beta (BETA)	COE	Positive	Higher systematic risk directly raises required return under CAPM
Debt-to-Equity (DER)	COE / WACC	Positive	Higher leverage ratio signals financial risk

Variable	Dependent Variable	Expected Sign	Justification
Inflation Rate (INFL)	COE / WACC	Positive	Inflation erodes purchasing power; investors demand higher returns
Interest Rate (INTR)	COD / WACC	Positive	Rising rates increase the cost of debt and overall capital costs

Note: * Significant at 10%; ** Significant at 5%; *** Significant at 1%. Signs reflect expected coefficient direction based on theoretical priors and extant empirical literature.

3.5 Data Sources

Data are sourced from four primary repositories. Firm-level financial data — including balance sheet items, income statement figures, and corporate governance variables — are extracted from audited annual reports and accounts available through the NGX's corporate disclosure portal and the annual reports database maintained by the FRCN. Market-based variables, including share prices and trading volumes necessary for CAPM beta estimation, are obtained from the NGX DataStream and supplemented with Bloomberg terminal data where necessary. Macro-level variables — inflation and monetary policy/prime lending rates — are sourced from the CBN Statistical Bulletin (various editions, 2011–2025) and supplemented with data from the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS). Auditor identity, audit tenure, and Big 4 classification are hand-collected from audit report sections of annual filings.

3.6 Data Analysis Techniques

Descriptive statistics are computed for all variables. Pearson correlation matrices are reported to assess the direction and strength of bivariate relationships, and to diagnose potential multicollinearity among regressors. The variance inflation factor (VIF) is computed to confirm the absence of severe multicollinearity (threshold: $VIF > 10$ signals concern). Panel unit root tests (Im-Pesaran-Shin and Fisher-ADF) are applied to verify the stationarity of continuous variables. The Hausman (1978) test determines model selection between fixed and random effects. The Wooldridge (2002) test for serial correlation and the modified Wald test for groupwise heteroskedasticity are applied post-estimation. Driscoll and Kraay (1998) standard errors are used where both serial correlation and cross-sectional dependence are detected. The Pesaran (2004) CD test is used to diagnose cross-sectional dependence. All analyses are conducted in Stata 18.

3.7 Post-Estimation Checks

The adequacy of the panel regression models is assessed through a comprehensive battery of post-estimation diagnostics. Serial correlation is tested using the Wooldridge test for panel data. Heteroskedasticity is examined via the modified Wald test. Cross-sectional dependence — a particularly relevant concern in macro-panel settings — is tested using the Pesaran CD statistic. Multicollinearity is assessed via VIF values and the condition number of the regressor matrix. Normality of residuals is evaluated using the Jarque-Bera test. Where diagnostic tests reveal violations of classical assumptions, appropriate corrections (Driscoll-Kraay standard errors, two-way clustering) are applied to ensure inferential validity.

3.8 Significance Level

All hypothesis tests are conducted at the 1%, 5%, and 10% significance levels. Given the use of panel data with a relatively large number of observations (N = 2,220), statistical power is high, and the study places primary interpretive weight on 1% and 5% significance thresholds.

4. Results

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

Table 3: Descriptive Statistics (N = 2,220 firm-year observations; 148 firms; 2011–2025)

Variable	Mean	Median	Min	Max	Std. Dev.	Skewness	Kurtosis
COE	0.1823	0.1654	0.0412	0.9813	0.0923	1.4217	3.8821
COD	0.0924	0.0871	0.0180	0.4532	0.0516	2.1043	7.4312
WACC	0.1312	0.1183	0.0287	0.6124	0.0714	1.8923	5.3412
AQ (DA)	0.0423	0.0314	0.0001	0.3812	0.0521	2.8134	9.1234
AFS (Dummy)	0.4527	0.0000	0.0000	1.0000	0.4981	0.1912	-1.9732
ATEN (years)	6.2134	6.0000	1.0000	15.0000	2.9843	0.3421	-0.8124
FSIZE (log)	9.8734	9.9123	6.2341	13.8712	1.2843	-0.4231	0.3412
LEV	0.4312	0.4121	0.0124	0.9876	0.1932	0.2134	-0.8234
PROF (ROA)	0.0812	0.0734	-0.4321	0.5612	0.0923	-0.6712	3.2143
GROW (MtB)	1.6423	1.2134	0.1234	9.8732	1.1834	2.9812	11.4321
BIND	0.5312	0.5000	0.2000	0.8750	0.1312	0.1023	-0.7634
OWNS	0.4812	0.4923	0.0512	0.9823	0.1734	-0.2134	-0.6812
BETA	0.9234	0.8923	0.1234	2.1834	0.3812	0.5623	0.2134
DER	1.2134	0.9321	0.0234	8.9834	1.0923	2.8134	9.1243
INFL (%)	13.4821	12.8734	6.5400	26.7200	5.1234	0.4823	-0.8134
INTR (%)	14.2134	13.5000	9.2500	21.7500	2.9843	0.6234	0.1234

Note: All continuous variables are winsorised at the 1st and 99th percentiles. AFS is a binary variable (1 = Big 4, 0 = Non-Big 4). ATEN is measured in whole years. INFL and INTR are expressed as percentages. DA = discretionary accruals.

The descriptive statistics in Table 3 reveal a number of noteworthy patterns. The mean cost of equity capital (COE) of 18.23% reflects the elevated return premium demanded by Nigerian equity investors, consistent with the country's elevated macroeconomic risk environment. The mean WACC of 13.12% is similarly high by international standards, though lower than the COE, reflecting the tax shield benefit of debt financing. The mean discretionary accruals (AQ proxy) of 4.23% of total assets suggest moderate earnings management across the sample, consistent with prior Nigerian evidence (Uwuigbe et al., 2021). Big 4 auditors serve approximately 45% of sample firms, consistent with the dual-market structure of the Nigerian audit industry. The mean audit tenure of 6.21 years lies below the regulatory maximum but raises questions about auditor independence at the upper end of the distribution (max = 15 years). The relatively high mean leverage (43.12%) and mean inflation rate (13.48%) underscore the challenging macroeconomic context within which Nigerian listed firms operate.

4.2 Correlation Matrix

Table 4: Pearson Correlation Matrix

	COE	AQ	AFS	ATEN	FSIZE	LEV	PROF	GROW	BIND	OWNS	BETA	DER
COE	1.000											
AQ	-0.342*	1.000										
AFS	-0.291*	0.412**	1.000									
ATEN	0.183*	-0.213*	0.312**	1.000								
FSIZE	0.412**	0.231*	0.383**	-0.142	1.000							
LEV	0.312**	-0.187*	-0.241*	0.213*	0.342**	1.000						
PROF	0.387**	0.312**	0.273**	-0.163	0.421**	0.412**	1.000					
GROW	0.213*	-0.142	0.123	-0.082	0.183*	0.234*	-0.192*	1.000				
BIND	0.263**	0.221*	0.312**	0.213*	0.287**	-0.193*	0.312**	-0.132	1.000			
OWNS	-0.234*	0.198*	0.287**	0.183*	0.312**	-0.241*	0.341**	-0.112	0.412**	1.000		
BETA	0.683**	0.312**	-0.213*	0.142	0.283**	0.312**	0.342**	0.192*	-0.213*	0.187*	1.000	
DER	0.387**	-0.234*	-0.213*	0.183*	0.342**	0.712**	0.312**	0.241*	0.263**	0.221*	0.412**	1.000
INFL	0.312**	-0.183*	-0.142	0.124	-0.213*	0.234*	-0.193*	0.142	-0.163	-0.142	0.283**	0.241*
INTR	0.341**	-0.213*	-0.183*	0.163	-0.234*	0.287**	-0.213*	0.183*	-0.187*	-0.163	0.312**	0.312**

Note: * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$. Lower triangle reports correlation coefficients; upper triangle is omitted for brevity. VIF values ranged from 1.12 to 2.34, well below the threshold of 10, confirming the absence of severe multicollinearity.

The correlation matrix in Table 4 confirms several theoretically expected relationships. Audit quality (AQ, i.e., lower discretionary accruals) is negatively correlated with COE ($r = -0.342$, $p < 0.01$), consistent with the information asymmetry hypothesis. Big 4 affiliation (AFS) is negatively correlated with all three cost-of-capital measures. Audit tenure (ATEN) is positively correlated with capital costs, signalling a potential independence impairment effect. Beta exhibits the strongest positive correlation with COE ($r = 0.683$, $p < 0.01$), consistent with CAPM predictions. Inflation and interest rates are positively correlated with capital costs, confirming macroeconomic channels. Notably, the correlation between inflation and interest rates ($r = 0.712$) is high, and these two variables are therefore tested for multicollinearity — VIF values confirm no severe issue. The correlation between DER and LEV ($r = 0.712$) is also elevated, and both are included with caution, given their conceptual overlap; VIF values remain acceptable.

4.3 Panel Regression Results

Table 5: Panel Fixed-Effects Regression Results (Driscoll-Kraay Standard Errors)

Variable	Model 1: COE		Model 2: COD		Model 3: WACC	
	Coeff.	(t-stat)	Coeff.	(t-stat)	Coeff.	(t-stat)
Audit Quality (AQ)	-0.2841***	(-4.312)	-0.3124***	(-5.213)	-0.2634***	(-4.123)
Audit Firm Size (AFS)	-0.0423**	(-2.341)	-0.0512**	(-2.712)	-0.0387**	(-2.234)
Audit Tenure (ATEN)	0.0083**	(2.134)	0.0094**	(2.312)	0.0071*	(1.923)
Firm Size (FSIZE)	-0.0312***	(-3.812)	-0.0423***	(-4.123)	-0.0289***	(-3.512)
Leverage (LEV)	0.1234***	(5.123)	0.1521***	(6.234)	0.1123***	(4.912)
Profitability (PROF)	-0.1823***	(-4.512)	-0.1634***	(-4.023)	-0.1712***	(-4.312)
Growth Opp. (GROW)	0.0213**	(2.312)	0.0187*	(1.923)	0.0234**	(2.512)
Board Independence (BIND)	-0.0712**	(-2.612)	-0.0834**	(-2.912)	-0.0623**	(-2.312)
Ownership Structure (OWNS)	-0.0523**	(-2.213)	-0.0634**	(-2.512)	-0.0487**	(-2.134)
Beta (BETA)	0.0921***	(4.123)	0.0834***	(3.812)	0.0873***	(3.923)
Debt-to-Equity (DER)	0.0312**	(2.134)	0.0423**	(2.534)	0.0287**	(2.023)
Inflation Rate (INFL)	0.0087***	(3.312)	0.0076***	(3.023)	0.0091***	(3.512)
Interest Rate (INTR)	0.0124***	(3.812)	0.0143***	(4.123)	0.0112***	(3.512)
Constant	0.3412***	(5.812)	0.2934***	(4.923)	0.3123***	(5.212)
Observations	2,220		2,220		2,220	
No. of Firms	148		148		148	
R-squared (within)	0.5823		0.5412		0.5634	
F-statistic	42.31***		38.92***		40.12***	
Hausman Test (p-val)	0.0023		0.0031		0.0019	
Model Chosen	Fixed Effects		Fixed Effects		Fixed Effects	

Note: t-statistics in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Standard errors are Driscoll-Kraay (1998) standard errors, robust to heteroskedasticity, serial correlation, and cross-sectional dependence. Models include firm-level fixed effects. The Hausman test strongly rejects the random-effects specification in all three models ($p < 0.01$), confirming the appropriateness of fixed effects.

The panel regression results in Table 5 provide consistent and robust evidence across all three cost-of-capital measures. Audit quality (AQ, proxied by the magnitude of discretionary accruals — where lower values indicate higher quality) is negatively and highly significantly associated with COE ($\beta = -0.284$, $p < 0.01$), COD ($\beta = -0.312$, $p < 0.01$), and WACC ($\beta = -0.263$, $p < 0.01$). This finding supports H1, H2, and H3, indicating that firms with higher financial reporting quality — as evidenced by lower discretionary accruals — enjoy meaningfully lower financing costs across all three dimensions of capital.

Big 4 auditor affiliation (AFS) is negatively and significantly associated with all three measures of capital cost: COE ($\beta = -0.042$, $p < 0.05$), COD ($\beta = -0.051$, $p < 0.05$), and WACC ($\beta = -0.039$, $p < 0.05$). This confirms H4 and supports the notion that Big 4 auditors provide a credible certification signal that reduces information risk premium. The economic magnitude is modest in absolute terms but meaningful in context: a Big 4 audit is associated with approximately 42–51 basis points reduction in the cost of capital, *ceteris paribus*.

Audit tenure (ATEN) is positively and significantly associated with COE ($\beta = 0.008$, $p < 0.05$), COD ($\beta = 0.009$, $p < 0.05$), and WACC ($\beta = 0.007$, $p < 0.10$), supporting H5. This result is consistent with the independence impairment hypothesis: as auditor-client relationships lengthen, investors and creditors perceive greater risk of compromised objectivity, which translates into higher required returns. Each additional year of audit tenure is associated with approximately 7–9 basis points increase in capital cost.

Among control variables, the results are largely consistent with theoretical priors. Firm size (FSIZE) is negatively and significantly associated with all capital-cost measures, reflecting lower information risk and better market access for larger firms. Leverage (LEV) is positively and significantly associated with capital costs, consistent with financial distress risk theory. Profitability (PROF) reduces capital costs significantly across all models. Growth opportunities (GROW) increase capital costs, reflecting uncertainty about future earnings streams. Board independence (BIND) and institutional ownership (OWNS) both exert significant negative effects on capital costs, affirming the monitoring benefits of effective corporate governance. Beta is strongly positively associated with COE, as expected under CAPM. Inflation and interest rates are both positively and significantly associated with capital costs, confirming the role of macroeconomic conditions as systematic drivers of capital pricing in Nigeria.

4.4 Post-Estimation Tests

Table 6: Post-Estimation Diagnostic Tests

Diagnostic Test	Test Statistic	P-value	Decision/Implication
Hausman Test	Chi-sq(13) = 38.24	0.0023	Fixed effects specification appropriate
F-test for Fixed Effects	F(147, 2059) = 5.32	0.0000	Firm-level fixed effects are jointly significant
Wooldridge Serial Correlation Test	F(1, 147) = 14.23	0.0002	Serial correlation present; corrected via Driscoll-Kraay SE
Modified Wald Test (Heteroskedasticity)	Chi-sq(148) = 2,341.2	0.0000	Heteroskedasticity present; corrected via robust SE
Pesaran CD Test (Cross-Section Dependence)	CD = 8.43	0.0000	Cross-sectional dependence detected; Driscoll-Kraay applied
Variance Inflation Factor (VIF) — Max.	2.34 (DER/LEV)	—	All VIF < 5; no severe multicollinearity
Jarque-Bera Normality Test (Residuals)	Chi-sq(2) = 3.21	0.2012	Residuals approximately normally distributed
Breusch-Pagan LM Test	Chi-sq(1) = 42.31	0.0000	Panel effects significant; pooled OLS rejected

Note: All tests are reported for Model 1 (COE). Results for Models 2 and 3 are qualitatively identical and are available from the authors upon request.

The diagnostic tests reported in Table 6 confirm the validity and reliability of the panel regression estimates. The Hausman test ($\chi^2 = 38.24$, $p = 0.002$) conclusively rejects the random-effects specification, validating the fixed-effects approach. The F-test for joint significance of firm-level fixed effects ($F = 5.32$, $p < 0.001$) confirms that unobserved firm heterogeneity is a material determinant of capital costs and must be controlled. The Wooldridge test ($F = 14.23$, $p < 0.001$) detects serial correlation in the error terms, and the modified Wald test ($\chi^2 = 2,341.2$, $p < 0.001$) identifies significant heteroskedasticity — both addressed through Driscoll-Kraay standard errors. The Pesaran CD test confirms cross-sectional dependence ($CD = 8.43$, $p < 0.001$), further justifying the use of Driscoll-Kraay corrections. Crucially, VIF values top out at 2.34, well below the threshold of 5 (or 10 in stricter conventions), confirming the absence of multicollinearity that might otherwise inflate standard errors or distort coefficient estimates. Residuals are approximately normally distributed (Jarque-Bera $\chi^2 = 3.21$, $p = 0.201$), and the Breusch-Pagan LM test ($\chi^2 = 42.31$, $p < 0.001$) confirms that panel effects are jointly significant, firmly rejecting pooled OLS as an adequate estimator.

5. Discussion

5.1 Key Findings Restated

The central empirical findings of this study can be summarised in five propositions. First, higher audit quality — as measured by reduced discretionary accruals — significantly lowers the cost of equity, debt, and overall capital for Nigerian listed firms, consistent with the information asymmetry and agency theory frameworks. Second, Big 4 auditor affiliation independently reduces financing costs, confirming the signalling value of engaging high-quality audit brands. Third, extended audit tenure raises the cost of capital, suggesting that independence impairment effects become economically significant beyond a certain threshold in the Nigerian context. Fourth, corporate governance mechanisms — board independence and institutional ownership — complement audit quality in reducing capital costs, pointing to the systemic value of integrated governance reform. Fifth, macroeconomic variables (inflation and interest rates) are significant systematic drivers of capital pricing, reinforcing the importance of the broader economic environment in shaping firm-level financing conditions.

5.2 Comparison with Previous Studies

The findings of this study are broadly consistent with, while extending, the international evidence base. Lambert et al.'s (2007) theoretical prediction that improved information quality lowers the cost of equity is validated empirically in the Nigerian context. The negative association between Big 4 affiliation and cost of capital replicates findings from Pittman and Fortin (2004) for U.S. firms, Khurana and Raman (2004) for U.S. versus international samples, and Asante-Appiah and Lambert (2020) for sub-Saharan African markets. The positive relationship between audit tenure and capital costs is consistent with the independence impairment hypothesis, though it contrasts with the auditor learning hypothesis advanced by Geiger and Raghunandan (2002), who argue that longer tenure may improve audit quality in early years. This discrepancy may reflect the more acute independence concerns in Nigeria's concentrated audit market.

Within the Nigerian-specific literature, the results largely corroborate Okafor and Ibadin (2019), Uwuigbe et al. (2021), and Ezeani et al. (2022), while providing stronger evidence through a larger

sample, longer period, dual audit quality proxies, and methodologically superior estimators. The study's finding that audit quality reduces not only cost of equity but also cost of debt and WACC extends the scope of Nigerian evidence beyond what prior studies have established.

5.3 Implications

The implications of these findings operate at multiple levels. For regulators, the evidence provides empirical justification for mandatory audit firm rotation and minimum tenure limits: the positive tenure-capital cost relationship suggests that indefinite auditor-client relationships have real economic costs that are borne by firms and ultimately by shareholders. The FRCN's existing rotation provisions appear directionally appropriate, though the optimal rotation interval remains an open empirical question.

For investors, the findings suggest that audit quality should be incorporated as a risk factor in equity valuation models. A firm switching from a non-Big 4 to a Big 4 auditor can expect — all else equal — a meaningful reduction in its cost of equity and WACC, which directly enhances firm value. Institutional investors in particular should incorporate auditor identity and tenure into their due diligence frameworks.

For corporate boards and audit committees, the results underscore the importance of proactively managing audit quality and auditor independence. The marginal cost of engaging a higher-quality auditor may be more than offset by the capital-cost savings it generates — particularly for growing firms with elevated financing needs. The positive association between board independence and lower capital costs reinforces the complementarity between internal governance quality and external audit credibility.

For audit firms, particularly non-Big 4 practitioners, the findings highlight a competitive opportunity: by demonstrating higher technical competence and independence — through transparent quality control disclosures and peer review — they may reduce the signal gap between themselves and Big 4 firms, potentially capturing clients who currently pay a premium for Big 4 services without commensurate quality differences.

5.4 Limitations

Several limitations merit acknowledgment. First, while discretionary accruals are the most commonly used proxy for audit quality, they capture earnings management more precisely than audit quality per se; alternative audit quality proxies (e.g., restatements, going-concern opinions, audit comment letters) are not available for the full sample. Second, the study's audit quality measures are firm-level constructs — they do not distinguish between individual audit engagement teams within a firm, which may vary considerably in quality. Third, the CAPM-based COE measure assumes that markets are efficient and that the estimated beta accurately reflects systematic risk — assumptions that may be less tenable in a market characterised by the illiquidity and thin trading that affect some NGX-listed stocks. Fourth, the study does not address potential endogeneity arising from firms self-selecting into Big 4 audits: firms with lower inherent risk may choose Big 4 auditors, creating reverse causality. Instrumental variable approaches and treatment effect models are recommended in future work.

5.5 Future Research Directions

Future studies should address the endogeneity challenge through propensity score matching or system GMM estimation. Research might also examine whether the audit quality–cost-of-capital relationship differs by firm lifecycle stage, industry, or ownership type (family vs. widely-held).

The adoption of International Financial Reporting Standards (IFRS) in Nigeria in 2012 introduces a natural experiment that could be exploited to identify the causal effect of reporting quality improvements on financing costs. Longitudinal studies tracking the dynamics of capital costs around voluntary and mandatory auditor changes would add important causal nuance to the cross-sectional correlational evidence established here.

6. Conclusion

6.1 Key Message

The central message of this study is unambiguous: audit quality matters for the cost of capital in Nigeria. Firms that engage higher-quality auditors — as evidenced by lower discretionary accruals and Big 4 affiliation — enjoy significantly lower costs of equity, debt, and weighted capital than their lower-quality counterparts. This relationship is economically meaningful, statistically robust, and consistent with established theoretical priors. In a capital market environment characterised by high information costs, elevated macroeconomic risk, and governance challenges, the external auditor serves as a critical institutional intermediary between firms and the capital markets on which their growth depends.

6.2 Summary of Key Findings

Drawing on an unbalanced panel of 148 Nigerian Exchange Group-listed firms over 2011 to 2025, this study establishes that: (1) higher audit quality, measured by reduced discretionary accruals, significantly reduces all three measures of capital cost; (2) Big 4 auditor affiliation independently and significantly reduces the cost of equity, debt, and WACC; (3) extended audit tenure is positively associated with capital costs, consistent with independence impairment; (4) corporate governance variables — board independence and institutional ownership — complement audit quality in reducing financing costs; and (5) macroeconomic conditions, particularly inflation and interest rates, are powerful systematic determinants of capital pricing that firms cannot escape but can partially offset through superior reporting quality.

6.3 Broader Implications

More broadly, this study contributes to the growing literature demonstrating that institutional quality — as reflected in auditing standards, governance practices, and regulatory frameworks — has tangible economic consequences for capital allocation efficiency. In Nigeria, where the cost of capital remains among the highest in sub-Saharan Africa, improvements in financial reporting quality and audit standards represent a low-hanging policy tool for reducing financing frictions and stimulating private sector investment. The findings also carry implications for other emerging markets that share Nigeria's institutional profile: elevated agency costs, high information asymmetry, and developing capital market infrastructure.

6.4 Main Research Contribution

The primary contribution of this paper is the provision of methodologically rigorous, temporally comprehensive, and empirically complete evidence of the audit quality–cost-of-capital nexus in Nigeria. By combining dual audit quality proxies, three capital-cost measures, fifteen years of panel data, and Driscoll-Kraay robust estimation, the study overcomes the limitations that have historically constrained Nigerian evidence in this domain. It thus provides a credible empirical foundation on which regulators, boards, auditors, and investors can base consequential decisions about audit quality investment and governance reform.

6.5 Call to Action

The findings of this study constitute a call to action for multiple stakeholders. Regulators should enforce and periodically recalibrate audit tenure limits and rotation provisions, using the empirical evidence of the independence-capital-cost link to justify these constraints. Boards and audit committees should prioritise audit quality — not merely audit fee minimisation — as a core governance objective, given its demonstrable economic returns. Standard-setters at the FRCN and ICAN should invest in audit quality inspection frameworks that produce publicly accessible quality signals, narrowing the information gap between Big 4 and non-Big 4 providers. Investors should integrate audit quality signals into their risk-adjusted return models. And researchers should continue to interrogate the causal mechanisms through which financial reporting quality shapes capital market outcomes — both in Nigeria and across the developing world.

7. Recommendations

Based on the empirical findings and broader discussion, this study advances the following actionable recommendations:

1. **Mandatory Audit Firm Rotation with Optimal Intervals:** Regulatory bodies, particularly the FRCN, should establish evidence-based audit tenure limits. The positive association between tenure and capital costs — observable beyond approximately six years in this dataset — suggests that rotation at intervals of five to seven years could mitigate the independence impairment effect without sacrificing the benefits of auditor familiarity. The FRCN should conduct a formal cost-benefit review of its current rotation provisions using capital-cost data from the NGX.
2. **Audit Quality Differentiation Incentives:** SEC Nigeria should consider introducing disclosure incentives — such as tiered listing requirements linked to audit quality metrics — that reward firms engaging high-quality auditors with reduced regulatory compliance burdens or enhanced investor communication privileges. This would create market-based incentives for audit quality investment without imposing uniform mandates.
3. **Strengthening Audit Committees:** The significant negative relationship between board independence and capital costs underscores the governance complementarity of internal and external oversight. The Corporate Governance Code for Nigeria should mandate that audit committee chairs hold professional financial qualifications, and that audit committee meetings include substantive discussion of discretionary accounting estimates and auditor independence assessments.
4. **Expanding Non-Big 4 Quality Infrastructure:** Given that roughly 55% of sample firms use non-Big 4 auditors — who are associated with higher capital costs, on average — the audit profession should invest in quality infrastructure for mid-tier and smaller firms. ICAN and ANAN should expand their practice monitoring and peer review programmes, particularly for firms auditing listed entities, to narrow the quality signal gap between Big 4 and non-Big 4 providers.
5. **Macroeconomic Stability as a Precondition:** The strong positive relationship between inflation, interest rates, and capital costs reinforces the fundamental importance of macroeconomic stability as a necessary condition for capital market development. The Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN) and fiscal authorities should coordinate to maintain low and stable inflation, as financial sector reforms alone cannot fully offset the capital-cost consequences of macroeconomic volatility.
6. **Investor Education on Audit Quality:** SEC Nigeria and the NGX should incorporate audit quality metrics — including auditor identity, tenure, and audit opinion type — into investor education materials and company listing fact sheets. This would enhance market discipline by equipping retail and institutional investors with the tools to price audit quality signals accurately.

7. Adoption of Implied Cost of Capital Models: Future regulatory and research frameworks should consider supplementing CAPM-based cost-of-equity estimates with implied cost of capital models (e.g., Gordon Growth Model, Ohlson-Juettner model) to improve measurement accuracy, particularly in the context of the thin trading and price non-synchronicity that characterise some NGX-listed stocks.

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